

Question

'A truly great leader must not only rise above the crowd, but also often turn his back on it.' Discuss.

① public (IP)
② self-interested
③ only after considering their views

☐ This is a sensible and well-argued essay that evaluates the intrinsic qualities of great leaders.

- ◆ The writer's subject mastery and proficiency in language enable him to convey the complexities and challenges of leadership very well. This provides the reader with plenty of food for thought. Furthermore, he explains and substantiates his opinions effectively.
- ◆ He also uses a range of specific and up-to-date examples of truly great leaders who have risen above the crowd, turned their backs on it and forged ahead on the basis of their own convictions to create their own legacy.
- ◆ The focus on political leaders is perhaps understandable but a wider range of leaders (e.g. those in business) could have been included to give more breadth. Influential leaders who can be considered are Steve Jobs and Napoleo Franci.

The advent of globalisation and the fluid nature of social media are formidable forces that have transformed traditional notions of leadership. [1] Given the constant clanging of public opinion in a world so densely packed with information, leaders need to step up and establish a voice of authority to set direction and show others how to make sense of their surroundings. This very context of the twenty-first century is why a truly great leader would have to be [2] a rational voice of reason and rise above the cacophony of self-interest, and indeed, at times, reject the counsel of the populace.

[3] Winston Churchill once proclaimed, "The greatest argument against democracy is a five minute conversation with the average man in the street." [4] Misinformation, and the ignorance of the electorate, is very much a key argument for why strong leaders, often in the best positions to make decisions in the best interests of the nation, would have to rise above the crowd, and truly decide if the nation should accede to the wishes of the people. The average man on the streets may well be a patriot, but he also does not have a complete picture of domestic affairs, is not privy to the logic of the leaders, and subsequently may propose solutions which attack the symptom rather than the problem. In Singapore, several years ago, the proposed creation of the Integrated Resorts created much furore over the possible social problems and culture of gambling that may arise. Singaporeans, however, were not privy to the reality that Singapore's tourism industry,

[1] The writer begins his essay by explaining how the modern context makes the qualities implied in the question – fortitude, resilience and conviction – fundamental ingredients of great leadership.

[2] The writer aptly paraphrases and expands on the ideas in the question demonstrating both understanding and linguistic mastery.

[3] Beginning the paragraph with a quote from Winston Churchill – a renowned leader – serves to add interest value to the content paragraph as well as strengthen his argument.

[4] A clear topic sentence that is accompanied by elaboration of the limitations of giving too much credence to the "average man in the street."

for so long a cornerstone in her economic policy, was fast losing ground to other Asian countries such as Taiwan and Malaysia. [5] In retrospect, however, this decision has largely been beneficial to the preservation of Singapore as a tourism hub, as well as the creation of more jobs. The widely cited social problems have also been mitigated largely by the social safeguards that the government has put in place. Clearly then, the ignorance of citizens who may not share the same long-term vision of our leaders would create widespread opposition and a flurry of variant opinions. Strong and astute leaders would then have to rise above such commentary – if necessary, even turn their backs on it – to assess the merits of each policy decision.

[6] Another argument for the intransigence of leaders is that a belief first perpetuated by a few may quickly grip the crowd and descend into mob rule, and the emotions and passion involved would overrule the rational thought and careful consideration that goes into decision-making. Often, the propensity to be guided by the heart rather than the head leads to the blind leading the blind, expedited by social media platforms that disseminate whatever is in vogue. In such situations, it is all the more important for leaders to think impartially from the madness of the mob, and carefully assess the next step; if this is at the expense of popularity, [7] then so be it. The Arab Spring that began in Dec 2010 is a clear sign of how unruly masses, and the spreading of fallacious, limited views in a climate of political tumult can lead to even more disastrous effects on the welfare of the people. Then President of Egypt, Hosni Mubarak was deposed from his 30-year authoritarian rule. With the liberal activists too fragmented to impose their ideas on a regime they helped bring down, the Muslim Brotherhood seized power instead, forming Egypt's first democratically-elected government. Its new leader, Mohamed Morsi, filled the party cadres from the Brotherhood to entrench his rule, and was again deposed within a year in charge. While the symptoms in 2011 called for democracy, the conditions in Egypt were not ripe for its seeds to be sown, and its constitution did not provide for the protection of the opposition and minorities. The lesson to be learnt from the Arab Spring is that while the passion and disgruntlement of the people had brought Mubarak's regime to its knees, the myopia of those who had called for democracy and elections failed to foresee the emergence of yet another inadequate government, and that this democratic hysteria could be inflamed exponentially especially with

[5] The writer astutely uses the phrase "in retrospect" to draw attention to the idea that leaders may seem to make ostensibly dubious decisions at the time, but they are, in fact, sound. This is in keeping with the notion that a great leader should not mindlessly crave consensus.

[6] This is a clear topic sentence in which the writer systematically warns the reader of the ramifications of populism.

[7] The writer strongly argues that there have been occasions where political popularity was sacrificed for rationality. The examples that follow illustrate how the hallmark of great leadership would be to make wise decisions, no matter how unpopular.

Evaluation

the advent of social media platforms in the twenty-first century. A great leader in times of crises such as this would have calmed the tension instead of stoking the fires, and ensured that the transition to democracy would entail the entire package of free speech, free election, protection of minority voices, and not just the nominal elections which proved to be an isolated characteristic of Morsi's ill-fated period in charge.

[8] Finally, it is in the interests of people to make decisions that are self-serving in nature, rather than in the interests of the wider community. Great leaders would have to turn their backs on calls for populist decisions and policies, for they can be unsustainable, and while they may secure the political 'future' of the leaders, such decisions upset the long-term stability and strength of nations. If leaders were to pander to every whim and fancy of the populace, [9] it would also be unfeasible, especially in a globalised world where it would be impossible to represent the interests of every ethnic, religious or racial group. To accede to the wishes of the crowd would also marginalise the minority, threatening social cohesion and harmony. [10] In fact, to attempt a balancing act would be ridiculous, and great leaders should simply make decisions in the best interests of the wider community, especially as the crowd can be motivated by self-interest and greed. The global financial crisis in 2008 was due to the accumulation of huge debt deficits run up by governments who had made promises to its supporters and could only sustain them by borrowing. The liberal spending of the West and the subsequent economic demise of economies like Greece and Spain who are experiencing unemployment levels of 50% among youths even today, serve as a cautionary example of how liberal spending and its inherent unsustainability are, ultimately, to the detriment of the people themselves.

[11] The caveat that we should undoubtedly abide by is that great leaders should only turn their backs on the crowd having considered their views and opinions, and decided it would be to the detriment to follow them whether in the long term, or to the minority groups. The democratic principles of plurality obviously point to the necessary consultation of the people for political longevity, but this should be especially so in this age where people have become more politically conscious and literate. In such a context, seeking the views of the people can only be a good thing. The function of the

[8] The writer provides an appropriate signal to indicate his third argument.

[9] and [10] This is a reminder that leaders face the insurmountable challenge of meeting multifarious needs in a globalised world. Therefore, one solution would be to make decisions that lead to the greatest good. Once again, the writer employs an assertive tone that reflects his conviction.

[11] The writer balances the essay with a caveat and explains when it would be appropriate for leaders to reject or contradict public opinion while carrying out their roles and responsibilities.

crowd would be to serve as a check and to hold the leaders accountable for their decisions. The voices of the very electorate that propped up these leaders deserve to be heard and considered, and insensitivity to the crowd's opinions is, in fact, a catalyst for the problems of the aforementioned mob rule and populist policies. [12] In Singapore, for instance, the Lee Hsien Loong administration is moving away from a more insistent, maximum, rule of the first generation People's Action Party. The recent Pioneer's Generation Package, tightening of foreign labour and moves to reduce academic stress, are all steps in consideration of the views of the people and that can be a good thing, especially in an increasingly politically-literate Singapore.

[12] Most readers would probably be able to identify with the local example that captures how leadership style must necessarily adapt to a changing populace.

As Singapore's former Prime Minister Lee Kuan Yew once proclaimed, [13] "If you are concerned about whether your rating will go up or down, you are not a leader." The principle that leaders should ultimately abide by, is to take into account the wishes of their people, while still standing by their principles and what they believe is the best path for their people.

[13] An apt quote to end the essay which encapsulates the writer's thesis.

